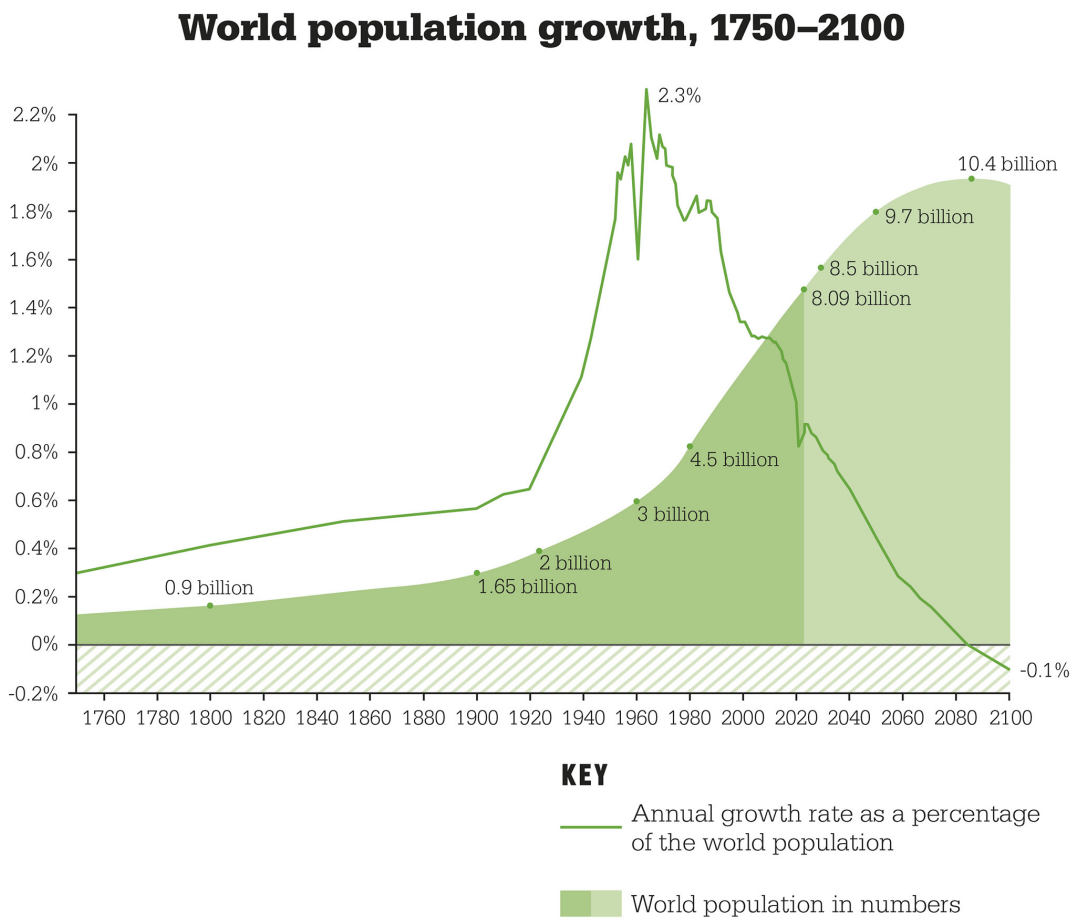


This graph plots a comparison between the annual growth rate of the world population and the total population in absolute numbers. The data for the years after 2023 is a projection.

Read accessible description

A slowing birthrate

In Europe and North America in the 20th century, wider access to birth control, better education, and more women entering the labor market resulted in lower birth rates. This phenomenon is now being replicated for women everywhere. Although the world's population passed 4 billion in 1974, 6 billion in 1987, and 8 billion in 2022, the annual rate of increase peaked near the end of the 1960s at 2.5 percent a year. Populations are still growing quickly in Africa, which is the fastest-growing continent. However,